was credibility in the science, the PMO and authorities in the Ministry of Health were most certainly open to taking up his recommendations. When he made the presentation, there certainly was merit in his suggestions to build capacity on a war footing. Just like many other scientists and political leaders, he too opined that the country must go into immediate lockdown, albeit with a caveat that India did not have the luxury to lock down. Other suggestions from him about not mandating mask wearing or not conducting RT-PCR (reverse transcription– polymerase chain reaction) tests on asymptomatic patients didn't seem to be backed by new, emerging, evidence-based practices.

Just like him, several other Indian scientists and doctors were also reaching out to the PMO before speaking extensively to the media. One prominent name was Dr Devi Shetty, cardiac surgeon and founder of Narayana Health, a chain of 21 medical centres in India and a recipient of the Padma Shri and Padma Bhushan awards in 2004 and 2012, respectively, for his contribution to the field of affordable healthcare in India. Dr Shetty was in touch with the PMO right from early March, providing insights and advice on capacity building that India should undertake, right from building temporary facilities, onboarding more doctors and nurses, increasing testing capacities and guiding the GoI on SOPs for patient care.

In mid-March, with the onslaught of new cases within the country on the verge of entering Stage 3 of the disease, which would mean community transmission of the contagion, Dr Shetty reached out to Principal Secretary Dr Mishra, who advised that we could no longer consider a partial lockdown as a mitigation measure since the virus was extremely contagious and transmissible. Only a complete restriction on movement would reduce viral transmission dramatically. In one of his interviews later that week to *The Times of India*, Dr Shetty reiterated what he communicated to Dr Mishra, that if India didn't shut down now, we would be forced to shut down a month later, when cases would have exploded and our healthcare facilities would be totally overburdened. He added that most western countries in the grip of the pandemic were too late in responding with locking down. If Lombardy, a city with the most advanced healthcare system in the world, couldn't ventilate all its elderly population presenting at emergency wards, then India would not stand a chance without significantly upgrading capacities in the weeks of locking down.[1]